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New legislation cracks down on street racing by penalizing sideshows

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New legislation authored by Assemblyman Vince Fong and signed into law Thursday by Gov. Gavin Newsom aims to crack down on street racers by suspending the driver licenses of convicted sideshow participants for up to six months.

Assembly Bill 3 states a sideshow is where "two or more persons block or impede traffic on a highway," to do motor vehicle stunts or speed contests for spectators. The legislation becomes effective July 1, 2025.

"Illegal sideshows are devastating families," Fong, R-Bakersfield, said. "They are claiming innocent lives in communities throughout the state of California. They are creating serious risk for our youth."

California law currently punishes engaging, aiding and abetting in a street race by no more than 90 days in county jail, a fine up to $500, or both.

The new law allows courts to not only suspend licenses for individuals convicted of engaging in a sideshow, but also restrict driving to purposes of their employment. Judges must also consider an individual's hardships when determining whether to suspend or restrict a driver's license, according to the bill.

Fong said the legislation codifies the definition of sideshows into California law for the first time. Many law enforcement agencies have a difficult time stopping street races, he added. However, officers can penalize those participating in sideshows and stop them from engaging in an eventual car race, Fong said.

Democratic Assembly members Laura Friedman, Jesse Gabriel, Adrin Nazarian and State Sen. Susan Rubio co-authored the bill. Fong said the tragic deaths around California attracted bipartisan support.

"This issue is a statewide public safety challenge," Fong said. "We began to talk and communicate with different law enforcement agencies. They needed more tools and they needed some assistance ... that was how AB 3 came about."

Many roads were lightly used during the pandemic, providing many with long stretches of uninterrupted space to race, the assemblyman said. Though street racing existed before the pandemic, data shows street races skyrocketed during this time, Fong added.

According to the assemblyman, the California Highway Patrol responded to more than 25,000 calls and the Bakersfield Police Department fielded over 6,000 calls involving illegal street racing activity in 2020.

"We're talking about safety of our roads and streets," Fong said. "It's not just motorists — but it's pedestrians, bicyclists. It's anyone on the road."

The assemblyman said he hopes to partner with Central Valley motorsports organizations and speedways in the future to open avenues for safer car racing.

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